

Rituals without Rapprochement? Managing Hostility at the Tripartite Meetings in the United Nations Mission in Lebanon

VANESSA F. NEWBY
Monash University, Australia

CHIARA RUFFA 
Sciences Po, France

How do rituals function in peace and conflict settings? How do rituals between adversaries contain and sustain emotions? In this article we examine the Tripartite Meetings hosted by the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), which were held regularly from August 2006 until October 2023 along the Blue Line that separates Israel and Lebanon. Mediated by UNIFIL, these meetings brought together representatives of the Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) and the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) to discuss tactical and operational issues. We argue that the Tripartites functioned as a ritual: highly routinized, symbolically vital, and carefully choreographed. Yet rather than fostering solidarity or emotional connection, this ritualized setting contained and reproduced antagonistic emotions of blame, injustice, and victimhood. In so doing, the meetings sustained an artificial equilibrium that deferred political action, creating the space for multiple parties to the conflict to re-arm. Our findings complicate Durkheimian assumptions that suggest rituals bind through shared affect, showing instead that in conflict settings, rituals can stabilize adversarial relations without advancing rapprochement. This study contributes to international relations debates on practice theory, emotions and the ambivalent role of rituals in conflict resolution initiatives, like peacekeeping and diplomacy.

¿Cómo funcionan los rituales en contextos de paz y conflicto? ¿De qué maneras contienen y sostienen las emociones los rituales entre adversarios? En este artículo analizamos las reuniones tripartitas organizadas por la Fuerza Interina de Naciones Unidas en Líbano (FINUL), que se celebraron de forma regular desde agosto de 2006 hasta octubre de 2023 a lo largo de la Línea Azul que separa Israel y Líbano. Estas reuniones, en las cuales FINUL ejercía de mediadora, reunieron a representantes de las Fuerzas Armadas Libanesas (FAL) y de las Fuerzas de Defensa de Israel (FDI) con el fin de debatir asuntos tácticos y operativos. Argumentamos que estas reuniones tripartitas funcionaban como un ritual: altamente rutinizadas, simbólicamente vitales y cuidadosamente coreografiadas. Sin embargo, en lugar de fomentar la solidaridad o la conexión emocional, este escenario ritualizado contenía y reproducía emociones antagónicas de culpa, injusticia y victimismo. Por esa razón, las reuniones mantenían un equilibrio artificial que difería de la acción política y creaba un espacio para que múltiples partes del conflicto se rearman. Nuestras conclusiones complican las suposiciones durkheimianas, que sugieren que los rituales unen a través del afecto compartido. Por el contrario, nuestras conclusiones demuestran que, en contextos de conflicto, los rituales pueden estabilizar relaciones adversariales sin promover un acercamiento. Este estudio contribuye a los debates en el campo de las Relaciones Internacionales sobre la teoría de la práctica, las emociones y el rol ambivalente de los rituales en las iniciativas de resolución de conflictos, como el mantenimiento de la paz y la diplomacia.

Comment les rituels fonctionnent-ils dans des environnements pacifiques et conflictuels ? Comment les rituels entre adversaires contiennent-ils et entretiennent-ils les émotions ? Dans cet article, nous examinons les réunions tripartites organisées par la Force intérimaire des Nations Unies au Liban (FINUL), qui se sont tenues régulièrement entre août 2006 et octobre 2023 le long de la ligne bleue qui sépare Israël et le Liban. La FINUL agissant comme médiateur, ces réunions ont rassemblé des représentants des Forces armées libanaises (FAL) et de Tsahal pour discuter de questions tactiques et opérationnelles. Nous affirmons que les réunions tripartites ont fait office de rituel : extrêmement routinières, vitales sur le plan symbolique et chorégraphiées avec précision. Pourtant, au lieu d'encourager la solidarité et la connexion émotionnelle, ce cadre ritualisé a contenu et reproduit des émotions antagonistes : culpabilité, injustice et statut de victime. Ce faisant, les réunions ont entretenu un équilibre artificiel qui a retardé l'action politique, créant ainsi l'espace nécessaire au réarmement des différentes parties au conflit. Nos conclusions compliquent les hypothèses durkheimiennes selon lesquelles les rituels lient par le biais d'un affect commun, montrant plutôt que dans les environnements conflictuels, les rituels peuvent stabiliser les relations antagonistes sans promouvoir le rapprochement. Cette étude contribue aux débats des relations internationales sur la théorie de la pratique, les émotions et le rôle ambivalent des rituels dans les initiatives de résolution des conflits, comme le maintien de la paix et la diplomatie.

Keywords: rituals; the micro turn; emotions; conflict resolution; interpretivism; Lebanon.

Introduction

Ritual theorists frequently stress the unifying effects of shared emotional experience, suggesting that rituals create

bonds of solidarity and moral community (Durkheim 1912; Victor 1969; Collins 2004). Yet in settings marked by peace and conflict, rituals can take on more complex, even counterintuitive, functions. In this article, we examine the Tripartite Meetings of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), where Israeli and Lebanese military officers met

*Corresponding author: Sciences Po, France. Email: chiara.ruffa@sciencespo.fr.

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under UN mediation from 2006 to 2023. We ask, how do rituals function in peace and conflict settings? How do rituals between adversaries contain and sustain emotions? We find in this case that rather than fostering rapprochement, these encounters ritualized the containment of antagonistic emotions: mutual blame, resentment, and victimhood; that crystallized tensions rather than resolving them. By tracing how the Tripartites were constituted and sustained, we show how rituals can manage hostility while reproducing division, complicating Durkheimian assumptions about the unifying power of rituals.

The Tripartite Meetings (hereafter “the Tripartites”) were a unique UNIFIL innovation, held from August 14, 2006, to October 7, 2023, along the Blue Line, the line of withdrawal separating Lebanon and Israel, which remained officially at war for the duration of these encounters. Emerging as a spontaneous, bottom-up initiative in the aftermath of the 2006 Israeli–Hizballah War, the meetings addressed tactical and operational security concerns, particularly territorial incursions and armed clashes along the Blue Line, in order to prevent escalation into wider conflict. Hosted and chaired by UNIFIL, the Tripartites brought together the Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) and the Israel Defense Forces (IDF), the official parties to Resolution 1701.¹ While never addressing the political causes of the conflict, the meetings became an important part of UNIFIL’s work that continued for 18 years. The meetings had a clear tactical impact: for 18 years they introduced a degree of predictability into the security environment in South Lebanon, helping to prevent flare-ups and potential escalations.

In this article we contend that the Tripartites can be understood as a ritual, which we define as “a regularly repeated, traditional, and carefully prescribed set of behaviors intended to symbolize a value or a belief” (Houlst 1974, 275). We find the Tripartites to be a ritual because of (1) the routinized, regular, and prescribed set of behaviors for the meetings that were put in place by UNIFIL and (2) unlike a practice, routine, habit, or norm, the Tripartites were considered symbolically vital for the mission by UNIFIL officers. Our research found that UNIFIL staff held the Tripartites in very high regard, viewing them as essential to the mission’s success and as a forum with the potential to broaden dialogue and, over time, open pathways toward a more durable political settlement. As such, the view was that they needed to be sustained and preserved at all costs. This belief was supported by UN HQ: UN Secretary General reports have repeatedly acknowledged the important contribution of the Tripartites to international peace and security.²

In this article, we focus predominantly on the perspective of the UN peacekeepers who managed and mediated the meetings. We show how the ritual nature of the Tripartites became part of the problem they were meant to solve. We found the formulaic choreography of the meetings made encounters predictable and safe, and UNIFIL’s use of avoidance tactics functioned as part of the interaction ritual, limiting the scope of discussion and directing attention to manageable issues. This narrowing preserved the ritual order of the meetings and minimized the risk of accidental flare-ups but also ensured that difficult conversations were deferred. As such, rather than fostering solidarity or emotional connection, this ritualized setting contained and reproduced an-

tagonistic emotions of blame, injustice, and victimhood between the parties.

The Tripartite Meetings helped to sustain a semblance of calm along the Blue Line. With direct armed escalations between the IDF and the LAF rarer, Hizballah had fewer opportunities to justify direct military action on the grounds of defending Lebanon. This lull did not resolve underlying tensions; rather, it created space for both the IDF and Hizballah to rebuild capacity, recalibrate strategy, and prepare for the next round of conflict. In this sense, while the Tripartites were designed to defuse tensions, ultimately, the ritual’s practical effects diverged from its intended function (see the introduction to this Special Forum for further discussion of the rationality–functionality–performativity distinction in ritual action).

In this article, we study a ritual in the context of a conflict that is highly relevant to international relations (IR) in that it continues to pose a threat to international peace and security.³ In so doing, we contribute to existing debates about rituals in international politics in three ways. First, a burgeoning body of scholarship within IR is increasingly focusing on microdynamics, often labeled “micropolitics” and “micromoves,” which are “defined not by the smallness of its elements but by the nature of its ‘mass’” (Solomon and Steele 2017; Nair 2020). As such, we treat the Tripartites as one of these micromoves because it tells us something broader about how arch enemies work with each other and particularly about the promise and pitfall of rituals in international interventions and military diplomacy. Previous research has shown how the microlevel can highlight broader dynamics relevant to international politics. Autesserre, for instance, showed how specific frames by peacebuilders shaped the failure of the international intervention in the Democratic Republic of Congo (Autesserre 2014). Similarly, Pouliot focused on “pecking order” in multilateral diplomacy (Pouliot 2016), and Ruffa and Rietjens wrote about peacekeepers’ meaning-making strategies that reinforced or weakened racialized hierarchies among UN members (Ruffa and Rietjens 2023). Our contribution here is to explore the interaction between agents—the participants—in the Tripartites, and the microstructure that is the Tripartites themselves. This allows us to study how “micropolitical lenses reveal sites that promise to reshape how we view global politics and our place in it” (Solomon and Steele 2017, 4). By studying the Tripartites, we are able to observe the role of the United Nations as a facilitator and, to a lesser extent, observe interactions between military agents of two countries at war.

Second, we also contribute to ongoing conversations about rituals in IR. Existing scholarship tends to assume that emotions are constitutive of rituals that unite groups of people in a shared emotion (Durkheim 1912; Goffman 1967; Collins 2004). We complicate that assumption and show that rituals can simultaneously sustain antagonistic emotions between parties, rather than agonistic ones that generate emotional closeness and group solidarity. While the IR literature acknowledges the role of rituals in micromoves and treats shared emotions and affect as constitutive of ritual action, it has yet to disentangle how antagonistic emotions shape ritual dynamics. Furthermore, most conflict resolution research has predominantly focused on elite-level, international diplomatic negotiators with wider margins of maneuver. Instead, we focus on military diplomacy because the

¹UNSCR Resolution 1701 was the mandate that brought an end to the 2006 war between Hizballah and the Israel Defense Force (IDF).

²See all United Nations Secretary-General reports on the implementation of Resolution 1701 (2006–2023). In addition, peacekeepers we interviewed noted that there were efforts to export the Tripartite model to other contexts.

³The most recent conflict between Hizballah and the IDF showed that there remains a possibility (however small) of nuclear escalation between Israel and Iran. See <https://www.csis.org/analysis/escalating-war-between-israel-hizballah-and-iran>

Tripartites are carried out and led by national actors: top-ranking military professionals from the participating parties' militaries as well as United Nations staff. Following Solomon and Steele, we capture the dynamics of rituals by studying its "mutually interwoven factors of affect, space and time" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 24).

Third, we see the Tripartites as one of those enclosures in which we can capture, study, and understand the role that peacekeepers play in brokering peace between two enemies. At a time when multilateralism is increasingly under threat, a better understanding of how rituals function in peace and conflict settings is more important than ever for international peace and security (Karlsrud 2023). Most quantitatively oriented research on peacekeeping has traditionally emphasized the important role that peacekeeping plays in overcoming information asymmetries and deterring conflict parties (Fortna 2008; Hultman, Kathman, and Shannon 2019). But recent scholarship across the quantitative-qualitative divide has highlighted that there is a need to understand *how* peacekeeping works and to refine and expand those mechanisms (Howard 2019). Our paper contributes to that conversation showing that peacekeeping mechanisms are more complex and while the Tripartites did reduce information asymmetries, they did so in a way that contributed to the nonresolution of the conflict. We therefore also contribute to debates about how peacekeeping works and when it fails (Autesserre 2014; Ruffa 2014, 2018; Newby 2017, 2018a, 2018b; Howard 2019). Understanding the processes and practices involved in bringing enemies into the same room provides useful empirical insight into *how* peacekeepers reduce information asymmetries, which has been much less studied. This article is also the first attempt to study the Tripartite meetings in detail and understand how they work.

The remainder of this paper has four parts. First, we position ourselves in relation to existing debates within the microturn in rituals, IR, and microsociology and develop our argument. Second, we briefly discuss our methodological approach and its limitations. Third, we put the Tripartite Meetings into the broader context of UNIFIL and the conflict situation to contextualize our research. Fourth, we illustrate how the Tripartites function as a ritual in military diplomacy and we explore its implications for the broader strategic context. Finally, we draw some conclusions about how rituals can help or hinder conflict resolution.

The Micro Turn in International Politics and a Microsociological Approach to Rituals

Agents, repeated practices, and emotions within the micro turn in IR

A vibrant body of literature in IR has turned to the so-called "micromoves" in IR as a way to challenge some of the more conventional IR paradigms (Autesserre 2014; Newby 2016; Solomon and Steele 2017; Bramsen 2023). This micro turn in the literature has allowed for a greater focus on agents that had remained invisible and taken their voices more seriously (Åhäll 2019; Bjorkdahl, Hall, and Svensson 2019). Solomon and Steele note that "this increased shift to the micro" has enabled IR "to (re)discover the lives and people of global politics, and to breathe life back into a field that grand theory mostly neglected" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 268). Solomon and Steele remind us to pay attention to the everyday, which is about how the international "is experienced and lived by ordinary people" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 274). The micro turn, therefore, enables research not only to make visible key agents of international politics but also to develop tools

to study practices and the everyday. We follow their call and bring into conversation three literatures: the micro turn in IR, rituals, and peacekeeping.

In this article, we build on research that does not regard peacekeeping as a black box or unified entity. Scholars in this vein examine the different microstructures and agents that compose a peace operation to understand how they function and where they can be effective.⁴ This microturn, therefore, is not only about agents but also about microstructures operating in global politics. We add to this turn in IR and peace and conflict studies by exploring the Tripartite Meetings as a microstructure, and the agents taking part in it. In line with similar work by Bramsen (2023), this research shows how what occurs at the micro level can have an impact on the trajectory of negotiations of low-intensity conflicts.

The microturn in IR also reminds us of the prevalence and importance of everyday practices. Micropolitics are those features of social life "...that often slip through our normal schematic or binary frameworks...these features that often form the unspoken but experiential constitution of our larger categories of nation, state, economy, security, and so on" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 270). As Pouliot wrote "it is not who we are that drives what we do; it is also what we do that determines who we are" (Pouliot 2010, 5); in other words, as the old adage goes: we are what we repeatedly do. Those practices provide "background knowledge that actors' habitually draw upon their behaviour" (Bigo 2011, 233).

Within practice theory, the micro turn has focused on diplomats (Pouliot 2016), while military actors have been largely overlooked. In the study of war and conflict, the agents directly involved are often invisible. Critical military and security studies have long noted this gap, with scholars observing that the field has "never really studied war from the perspective of most who participate in it," including soldiers and officers (Barkawi 2011; Basham, Belkin, and Gifkins 2015). Yet military personnel are a crucial part of what Sylvester calls "the social aspect of war" (Sylvester 2012, 483): elites in some respects but also operating with limited agency within highly hierarchical structures. This article brings those actors to the fore, exploring the spaces in which they operate and how they use emotions in this context.⁵ Another literature that has paid attention to the microprocesses of practices is the literature on rituals to which we now turn.

Emotions in rituals

A weakness of practice theory has been its neglect of the emotional lives of agents involved in practices, which is a "notable oversight" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 11). The literature on rituals tries to address this gap by emphasizing the importance of emotions in both the emergence, constitution, and persistence of formalized and meaningful practices, such as rituals.

The literature on rituals in IR acknowledges the critical role that emotions play, relying heavily on symbolic interactionism (Blumer 1986). Scholars in this genre have observed that emotions are both constitutive of rituals and facilitate their function: They unite people, create cohesion and a sense of belonging, help resolve conflicts, and provide a stable platform for addressing differences from prior engagements (Aalberts et al. 2020; Mälksoo 2021; Baele and Balzacq

⁴See for example, research has studied mission leadership (Bove, Ruffa, and Ruggeri 2020), the concept of credibility (Newby 2018a), and racialized hierarchies within peace operations (Ruffa and Rietjens 2023).

⁵We acknowledge that by bringing these intervening actors to the fore we are leaving others underexplored, such as the local population which is beyond the scope of the article.

2022; Bramsen 2023). Collins defines a ritual as “a mechanism of mutually focused emotion and attention producing a momentarily shared reality, which thereby generates solidarity and symbols of group membership” (Collins 2004, 7). Geertz noted that “...in a ritual, the world as lived and the world as imagined, fused under the agency of a single set of symbolic forms, turns out to be the same world” (Geertz 1973, 112). For Geertz, every single behavior within the context of a ritual is believed to have both immediate as well as cosmic significance. Rituals create a subjunctive world, a “world-as-if,” in which everybody appears to agree with the definition of the situation produced by participants (Seligman et al. 2008 cited in Boussaguet and Faucher 2025, 17). Within a peace and conflict context, Bramsen shows how power dynamics in negotiation settings emerge locally from a specific social context, but that power also depends on emotional energy and is manifested in numerous microinteractions (Bramsen 2023).⁶ In line with the broader sociological literature on rituals, Bramsen suggests that emotional energy—and not only competent leadership—is necessary for successful negotiation (Bramsen 2023, 21). Along similar lines, Collins acknowledges the importance of collective effervescence that should lead to group solidarity, emotional energy, symbols of social relationship, and standards of morality.⁷

Importantly, however, there is more to rituals than emotions, and the role emotions play remains unclear. Kertzer contends that it is because they are formal, highly structured, repetitive, standardized, and “wrapped in a web of symbolism” that rituals can channel emotions, guide cognition, and organize social groups (Kertzer 1989, 9). Rituals, for instance, help authorities “to be seen to be in overall control of the situation (...); to avoid massive, unforeseen and uncontrollable public reactions” (Pault 1993, 43, 22). Somewhat differently, when Collins lists the “ingredients” for a ritual, shared mood is only one of those.⁸ For Collins, rhythmic interaction is at the center of shared mood, and a mutual focus of attention among the participants on the same object or event together constitutes “rhythmic entrainment.” Accordingly, such “interaction rituals are contexts in which participants develop a mutual focus of attention and become ingrained in each other’s bodily micro-rhythms and emotions” (Collins 2004, 47). Taken together, those perspectives acknowledge that emotional energy and solidarity are constitutive to rituals and connected to repetition and structure. What contradictory and suppressed emotions do in rituals remains somewhat less clear, and it is this connection in part that we are interested in unpacking.

Rituals in conflict settings

We have seen that actions in rituals are “symbolic expressions of sentiments” that are regularly repeated (Radcliffe-Brown 1977, 105). But in extreme situations, such as conflict, what happens to rituals? Sociologists emphasize the centrality of emotions in rituals associated with boundary activities and radical changes of status, such as death, birth, marriage, and puberty. To illustrate, for Benford and Kurtz, the ultimate boundary situation is the thoroughly modern problem

of the possibility of the annihilation of human life through nuclear warfare (Benford and Kurtz 1987, 366). For them, rituals provide solutions to problems, especially those involving difficult situations and uncontrollable forces. Rituals are rooted in experience, identify evil, and make boundaries; rituals reify social processes and reinforce social structures. In our case, the boundary activity is the possibility of conflict between the parties. Strong routines and choreography help to normalize and make the situation tolerable. While routines are an essential part of these rituals, rituals can be said to be more than routines because they are usually held sacred by one or more groups (Bolton 2024). The rituals literature implies that predictability, routines and choreography may enhance the emotional effervescence that Collins discusses, but we argue that those routines and rigid structures can also contribute to containing emotions that might otherwise need to be expressed.

We build on Bell’s argument that “ritualization is a strategy for the construction of a limited and limiting power relationship” (1992, 197). Such relationships do not entail absolute control but are marked by a dynamic interplay of consent and resistance, misunderstanding, and appropriation. Bell also shows how ritualized activities often operate in confined, structured spaces with restricted access, regular periodicity, formalized codes of communication, and the use of specialized personnel (1992, 204).

The Tripartites reflected this logic in a distinctive way. Elite technocratic officers from the IDF and the LAF met under UNIFIL’s chairmanship in a highly ritualized setting with fixed routines, specific locations, technical language, and a focus on everyday security concerns. These features enabled dialogue between archenemies who carried deep antagonistic emotions and narratives of blame, injustice, and victimhood. While each side located the source of suffering in the other, their emotions were contained by the ritual’s regimented format, and the use of avoidance tactics by UNIFIL.⁹

Benford and Kurtz note, “rituals provide solutions to problems on many levels” (1987, 466). One of the mechanisms by which this occurs is by “focusing attention on ritual details rather than on the uncontrollable aspects of a crisis situation” (1987).¹⁰ Rituals therefore provide “participants with a series of rationalizations that enable them to escape the angst associated with the crisis” as well as “a sense of security that are previously arranged” (1987). The Tripartites functioned similarly. Anxiety was prevalent on both sides, driven by concerns over the potential for conflict and the painful consequences that would emerge from this.

We illustrate how the ritualized nature of these interactions within the Tripartites made them predictable and minimized the risks of walkouts and suspensions. In practical terms, this helped to prevent and contain security incidents that could have triggered escalation. At the same time, their importance to UNIFIL and the ritualized process reduced their potential to be a catalyst for conflict resolution because they worked only to defuse immediate tensions, instead of resolving the issues at the heart of the conflict.

The Tripartites triggered three mutually reinforcing processes. First, their emphasis on immediate tactical deconfliction diverted attention from larger strategic questions. From the outset, all parties regarded this narrow focus as crucial—perhaps even the most important institutional priority. Second, the perceived importance of the meetings led UNIFIL

⁶Building on Bramsen (2023), we adopt a microsociological approach to rituals instead of relying on practice theory only. This is an important difference because microsociology allows us to capture change more than continuity as opposed to iterative practices.

⁷Collins—building on Durkheim—defines collective effervescence as “high absorption in emotional entrainment, whatever the emotion may be” (2004, 107–8).

⁸Collins’ ingredients are group assembly with bodily copresence; barriers to outsiders; mutual focus of attention among the participants in the same object, or even shared mood.

⁹Goffman (1967, 12) reflects on how the interaction order in a ritual is preserved through the selective use of avoidance tactics.

¹⁰For example, during a funeral, individuals concentrate on the rituals and details, thereby managing their anxiety and fostering commonality among participants.

to invest significant time and resources in them, creating a misleading sense of progress that was not matched by substantive political change. Third, as the meetings became increasingly institutionalized, outward displays of antagonistic emotions gradually became more muted. This dynamic supports Whitehouse (2000), Whitehouse (2004) distinction between “imagistic” rituals, which are rare and emotionally intense; and “doctrinal” rituals, which rely on repetition and routinization. Over time, the Tripartites shifted toward the latter: outwardly polite and emotionally restrained but underpinned by a “false equilibrium.” The ritual was intended to stabilize the security situation, but it instead created a semblance of calm, which provided the space necessary for IDF and Hizballah to rearm. UN peacekeepers immersed in their work with the Tripartites continued to work toward bringing the parties together, but this became increasingly disconnected from the broader strategic context.

Ultimately, the combination of these factors reveals how entrenched rituals can contribute to a cycle of inaction, perpetuating the belief in progress while real challenges remain unaddressed.

Our aim here is not to assert causality, but to operate through the lens of interpretivist causality (Norman 2021; Kurowska and de Guevara 2022). In this logic, “explaining an action requires locating it in the wider web of meaning” (Kurowska and de Guevara 2022, 8) and exploring how contextually specific meaning shapes the ways in which actors make sense of the world. As such, outcomes are explained through the meanings and understandings actors attach to their actions, rather than through direct cause-and-effect mechanisms.¹¹

To capture these dynamics, we adopt a focus on affect, space, and time proposed by Solomon and Steele (2017). Affect in their view is about the “flux of life which furnishes the material to our later reflection (...) and is more associated with becoming and intensity.” Space is understood “as socially produced rather than an empty or neutral category.” Time is understood “as rhythm offering novel insights into the micropolitical generation of broader collective identities at an embodied everyday level” (Solomon and Steele 2017, 18). A micropolitical approach is able to capture how “the affective energy may become mobile as changing intensities get “heated up or cooled down by the pressure-cooker of social interaction” (Solomon and Steele 2017, 12).

The micromoves literature implies that affect plays an important role in practices. Our argument nuances this picture. We find that emotions and affect are defused through the Tripartites ritual that were symbolically vital to UNIFIL. They included set routines, a sacred location, shared technical language, and a focus on technocratic, everyday security concerns. Intersecting movements of affect, space, and time/rhythm made the ritual ontologically possible and, at the same time, in this case, hampered the solidarity that is supposed to arise (Bramsen 2023, 21).

Methodological Reflections

We adopt an interpretive, site-intensive research strategy that allows the field to guide our inquiry (Fujii 2018; Schwartz-Shea and Peregrine 2013). Our ontology and epistemology treat knowledge as historically and contextually situated, and we seek to recover the beliefs and meanings that make particular actions possible (Bevir 2006). Interpretivism enables an inductive and abductive mode of analysis

in which ideas are developed iteratively through dialogue between theory and empirical material. Our argument, therefore, emerged through this abductive, back-and-forth process.

We conceptualize the Tripartites as a “microenclosure” that reveals how adversaries interact within UN-mediated spaces. They function as both a paradigmatic and deviant case: paradigmatic in the sense that they expose broader dynamics between parties at war (Soss 2019), and deviant because they depart from conventional expectations of ritual, allowing space for new theorization (Gerring 2017). Following Soss, we treat casing as iterative and dynamic, mirroring the evolving trajectory of our engagement with the field.

Our data collection follows a bottom-up, interpretive strategy. We prioritized participants’ own narratives rather than using standardized semi-structured interviews. We conducted eleven in-depth interviews—two with former IDF officers, two with LAF officers, and seven with UNIFIL peacekeepers—who were involved in the Tripartites between 2013 and 2023. Given the meetings’ secrecy and restricted access, our analysis centers on UNIFIL personnel, whose accounts led us to interpret the Tripartites as a ritual. Limited narratives from the IDF and LAF similarly emphasized their routinized and symbolically important character, with one IDF officer explicitly calling them a ritual.

To verify factual elements, we triangulated UNIFIL interviews with long-term conversations with Lebanese and Israeli officers (2007–2024) and media reporting. Ultimately, however, our account reflects an interpretation of UNIFIL’s perspective, and we remain cautious about generalizing beyond this vantage point.

This research faces several limitations. The Tripartites are highly secretive, involving two militaries that remain formally at war, making access difficult and direct observation impossible. Interview narratives therefore carried elements of self-justification, though they remained valuable for revealing how participants understood the ritual and its effects. Because outcomes were rarely shared with local constituencies, and local actors were neither informed nor consulted, their perspectives are absent from this analysis. Our main vantage point comes from UNIFIL peacekeepers, which risks overstating their influence or the significance they attributed to the meetings. While individual variation in peacekeeper posture is well documented (Newby 2018a), the Tripartites were tightly scripted and run by a relatively homogenous liaison and political affairs team, reducing the impact of such variation. Limited conversations with IDF and LAF officers nonetheless suggested that both parties were genuinely invested in the meetings, indicating that the ritual mattered beyond UNIFIL’s own framing.

The Tripartite Meetings in Context

UNIFIL was established in 1978 following Israel’s first invasion of Lebanon (Newby 2024). It was tasked with supervising withdrawal and contributing to stability in the south.¹² Its mandate evolved against the backdrop of recurring violence: the relocation of the PLO to southern Lebanon in the early 1970s and its raids into Israel, successive Israeli incursions and occupations, and the subsequent rise of Hizballah as the dominant armed actor along the border. Although the Ta’if Agreement formally ended Lebanon’s civil war in 1990 (Salloukh 2021), the Lebanese state remained too weak to

¹¹For a discussion of the differences between causal and constitutive explanations, see (Norman 2021).

¹²United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 425 (1978), Adopted by the Security Council at its 2074th meeting, on 19 March 1978. S/RES/425*. New York: United Nations, 1978. <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/73236>.

assert authority in the south, enabling Hizballah to consolidate its position (Norton 2014). By the early 2000s, cross-border skirmishes between Hizballah, and Israel had become routine, culminating in the 2006 war that caused over a thousand deaths and widespread destruction (Makdisi 2011).

UN Security Council Resolution 1701 ended the hostilities, strengthened UNIFIL's mandate, and for the first time since the civil war, triggered the redeployment of the LAF to the south of Lebanon (Barak 2009; Makdisi 2011). Since then, UNIFIL has operated between the Blue Line and the Litani River, monitoring violations, supporting humanitarian initiatives, facilitating demining, and enabling the LAF to establish a more consistent presence (Newby 2017). Yet suspicion persisted: Israel continued to assert that Hizballah maintained a military infrastructure in the area, backed by Syria and Iran, while questioning the LAF's capacity to enforce Lebanese sovereignty (Meier 2015a; Blanford 2017).

In this context, the Tripartite meetings were created as a mechanism to prevent clashes between the LAF and the IDF along the Blue Line. Although the two militaries have never formally been at war, they had no direct channels of communication, rendering UNIFIL's facilitation indispensable. The Tripartites thus provided a rare, institutionalized forum where the parties could address incidents, exchange accusations, and manage tensions, even as Hizballah remained absent. That fragile equilibrium collapsed in October 2024, when the Hamas attacks on Israel ignited renewed hostilities between Hizballah and Israel, culminating in a destructive 2-month war (Makdisi 2024; Newby and Ruffa 2024).

The Tripartites, therefore, must be understood within a wider history of unresolved sovereignty disputes, cyclical conflict, and acute civilian suffering (Kassem 2024). While they never addressed the root causes of the conflict, they institutionalized a space in which hostility could be managed and escalation temporarily contained. For international political reasons, Hizballah was never formally part of the Tripartites, and this very absence was important (Makdisi 2011). The impossibility of engaging with Hizballah potentially shaped the form and limited scope of the Tripartites. While the multiple reasons for Hizballah's absence from the Tripartites fall outside the scope of this article,¹³ it is important to underscore how the Tripartites were fundamentally shaped and limited by the circumvention of the reality of Hizballah's presence on the Blue Line.

LAF Engagement with the IDF

The LAF has always walked a political and legal tightrope in South Lebanon. While several elements within it have supported the prospect of a formal ceasefire with Israel, and indeed a peace deal, the army has always had to accommodate political preferences in Beirut, where in recent years the majority party in power has been Hizballah's political wing (Salloukh 2020). In addition, they have had to carefully balance the mandate of 1701, with local support for Hizballah from the Shi'ite majority local population in the south (Meier 2015), and within its own troops (Nerguizian 2009). This support for Hizballah is often solely predicated on the idea that only Hizballah can protect the local population from Israeli incursions.¹⁴ The 2006 war helped to reinforce the belief, as Hizballah was undefeated while the LAF did not engage

the IDF. Furthermore, Israel's policy of the "qualitative military edge" (QME) that prevents its neighbors from obtaining sophisticated defensive weaponry (Wunderle and Briere 2008) has meant the LAF lacks a basic level of weaponry that might be necessary for deterring these incursions. A South Lebanese civilian interviewed in 2013 summed up the situation: "We would prefer that the international community made a decision to allow the military to be armed properly, and then we don't need the resistance" (Newby 2018a, 128). Ultimately neither a national army nor a peacekeeping force is capable of enforcing a Hizballah withdrawal in the absence of political and legal agreement in Beirut, or local support in south Lebanon.

IDF Engagement with the LAF

Conversations with members of the IDF have confirmed a dismissive attitude toward UNIFIL, in line with views held more broadly in Israel.¹⁵ However, they viewed the Tripartites as uniquely valuable. One retired officer explained, "[T]he liaison and Tripartites is what is important in UNIFIL... the minute you have an organization you can leverage to communicate with the other side it becomes important."¹⁶ Another described them as "a platform... very important... over time you are able to learn many things about each other."¹⁷

Second, the Tripartites were valued not just as forums for dialogue but as tools for intelligence and monitoring. Officers emphasized their utility in tracking changes and reading signals: "there have been postponements... coordinating a date becomes difficult. Then you understand that it means something."¹⁸ The meetings were described as a way to "get a sense about the mood,"¹⁹ stressing, "if you ignore it, it may cause you other problems."²⁰

Third, the IDF recognize the Tripartites' political function in reinforcing the LAF, even though they see the LAF as closely tied to Hizballah. As one officer explained, "for the Lebanese officer... he's a legitimate representative of the State. It doesn't matter who actually controls Lebanon... we all come into that meeting with a briefing and our agendas."²¹ Another reflected, "Sometimes we come... because we know it strengthens the Lebanese army... it's an amazing opportunity for them." Yet he later added, "It's not a favour; it's a mutual acknowledgment. By recognizing each other's presence, both parties validate their existence."²²

It is in this context that the Tripartite Meetings were held for 18 years. Despite deep resentment on behalf of the LAF toward the IDF, and IDF animosity toward Hizballah, with whom it believed the LAF had substantial links, the meetings continued to run.

Tripartite success

The meetings ended abruptly in 2023 after the October 7 attacks. This was due to an escalation in attacks from Hizballah

¹³In short, Hizballah was not a named party to Resolution 1701 and as such was not included in such a formal interstate mechanism. Locally, UNIFIL engaged with local politicians across the entire Lebanese political spectrum, which included Hizballah as a political party.

¹⁴Up until 2023 there had been five incursions. On October 1, 2024, the IDF commenced its sixth incursion; see Newby (2024).

¹⁵A structured content analysis of UNIFIL articles in the Israeli media was conducted from February to July 2025. This identified 300 articles in the period 2006–2024. The articles overwhelmingly presented UNIFIL in a negative light. Some examples can be found here: <https://www.jpost.com/opinion/article-824789>; <https://www.haaretz.com/opinion/2024-10-18/ty-article-opinion/premium/unifil-in-south-lebanon-reminds-us-of-israels-famous-keystone-cop/00000192-963a-d751-a99f-de7fd7a80000>

¹⁶Interview with IDF officer A, January 12, 2023, Paris, Zoom.

¹⁷Interview with IDF officer A, January 12, 2023, Paris, Zoom.

¹⁸Interview with IDF officer B, October 27, 2024, Paris, Zoom.

¹⁹Interview with IDF officer A, January 12, 2023, Paris, Zoom.

²⁰Interview with IDF officer B, October 27, 2024, Paris, Zoom.

²¹Interview with IDF officer B, October 27, 2024, Paris, Zoom.

²²Interview with IDF officer A, January 12, 2023, Paris, Zoom.

on Israel's northern front in support of Hamas. The escalation illustrates the fragility of the ritual in the larger strategic conflict, and its fundamental disconnect from the broader macro-context. The meetings ended as suddenly as they had begun, despite having claimed many successes. Over the years they prevented escalations over serious issues of violence between the IDF and LAF that occurred on the border, such as the random shooting of an IDF soldier by an LAF soldier, and they stopped a 3-hour shoot-out between the LAF and the IDF at al-Adeisseh in 2010 (Newby 2018a). Furthermore, they were an effective conflict prevention mechanism; the meetings negotiated access for the parties to important infrastructure on the Blue Line, such as water sources; agreed on marking the Blue Line to reduce accidental transgressions; and made microagreements that enabled farmers in Lebanon to cross the Blue Line to harvest their crops. Perhaps the greatest achievement was the reduction of information asymmetries that for almost 20 years reduced the risk of accidental conflicts between the militaries of both states. At the same time, they created the space for the parties to rearm.

The Tripartites as a Ritual

We now turn to the empirical material to illustrate how the Tripartites were constituted as a ritual but failed to generate rapprochement. In so doing, we draw on the framework used by Solomon and Steele (2017) using the concepts of space, time, and emotions.

Tripartite choreography: time

The Tripartite meetings began immediately at the end of the 2006 war between Israel and Hizballah, with the first meeting held on the day the mandate came into effect (August 14, 2006). The initiative for the meetings came from three key staff within UNIFIL,²³ and the aim was to engage in dialogue the two officially named parties to resolution 1701: the LAF and the IDF. One of the Tripartite founders described the aim thus:

The mandate [Resolution 1701] came into effect on 14 August and we had a Tripartite on the 14 August. And the sole purpose...was to get the Lebanese Army...the state authority - into a room with the IDF.²⁴

From there on in, until October 7, 2023, the Tripartite meetings on average occurred every 1 month to 6 weeks.²⁵

With no formal institutional framework, the Tripartites relied on a simple performative act: At the close of each meeting, the parties were asked whether they wished to meet again. This convention, introduced in the very first session by the Force Commander, became ritualized. What began as a pragmatic gesture acquired symbolic weight, as the repetition of assent marked the continuation of the process and affirmed each side's commitment to the encounter. UNIFIL safeguarded this choreography, ensuring that every meeting ended with the same question and that the responsibility for convening the next round rested with the mission. Over eighteen years, this routine never changed, transforming an ad hoc arrangement into a ritual.

It was only when we came to the end of the meeting that we asked the parties, "Would you like to come back together again?". We didn't set any time

rules. So, the next meeting was predicated on whether they wanted to come back again, and they always wanted to come back again.²⁶

For UNIFIL, the most important outcome was securing the parties' agreement to meet again. This was not always easy: after tense incidents along the Blue Line, UNIFIL sometimes postponed meetings to allow tempers to cool before proposing a new date. At other times, the parties agreed to convene immediately—sometimes the very next day after a serious violation—in order to contain the situation and prevent escalation.

The Tripartites were structured through a carefully formalized choreography that encompassed the location, spatial layout, seating arrangements, and sequence of events. UNIFIL treated these elements as logistical details, but in fact they facilitated performative practices. In Goffman's (1959, 22) terms, this constitutes the "setting," the stage upon which interaction is rendered meaningful, underscoring that ritualized performance requires an ordered environment prior to its enactment.

We'd bring it together, we'd have a script, the FC speaks, and we have rehearsed everything.²⁷

The order of how the meetings took place was highly ritualized with each party taking it in turns to arrive first. One officer described it thus:

One delegation arrives a half an hour before the first. And we vary that each time generally... one delegation will arrive at nine if the meeting starts at 10. And they'll have a meeting with the Force Commander for maybe 20 minutes to half an hour and then they'll go downstairs into the room. And the other delegation will meet with the Force Commander for the same amount of time and they they'll go down into the room.²⁸

Tripartite choreography: ritualized space

The location of the meetings was always the same. They took place in a small building on the border between Israel and Lebanon at a place called Ras Naqoura (by the Lebanese) or Rosh Haniqra (by the Israelis). The location had been decided upon hurriedly for the first meeting, which had been held at very short notice, and which had made finding a suitable location a challenge:

First of all, we had to deal with the room. All these silly little things you know?... We need to get tables; we need to get chairs! I mean these are all the practicalities you don't even think about! And then OK, who is going to sit where?²⁹

To an outsider, the stage management of the Tripartites might seem overly meticulous, but such repetition was central to the ritual's continuity. As ritual theory reminds us, it is through sameness and fixity that symbolic power is generated.³⁰ UNIFIL therefore insisted that the meetings always take place in the same room and follow the same format, and one of the founders was adamant that neither location nor procedure should ever be altered.³¹ Several UNIFIL interviewees conveyed a strong belief, almost superstitious, that altering the location or format of the meetings might upset the

²⁶Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

²⁷Senior Political Affairs Officer, UNIFIL B, Tyre, South Lebanon, July 2, 2016.

²⁸UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

²⁹Senior Political Affairs Officer, UNIFIL B, Tyre, South Lebanon, July 2, 2016.

³⁰Randall Collins, *Interaction Ritual Chains* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2004); Catherine Bell, *Ritual Theory, Ritual Practice* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1992).

³¹Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

²³A senior political affairs officer, the force commander, and a military adviser.

²⁴Interview with Senior Political Affairs Officer, UNIFIL B, Tyre, South Lebanon, July 2, 2016.

²⁵The regularity of the meetings depended heavily on the parties willingness to meet, and the UNIFIL Force Commander's commitment to holding regular meetings.

fragile balance, changing the dynamic that had allowed the process to endure.

We would be extremely protective about the Tripartite. Because anything that would hamper it or damage it or make it not work would be a disaster.³²

This ritualized space appeared to serve several functions.³³ First, it generated its own dynamics that enabled agreements beyond what was possible bilaterally. Even when one side's support for a proposal waned, the parties consistently returned to the table and continued to make concessions.

I remember the IDF wrote to me one time and said they were not going to agree to mark the Blue Line anymore...they held back for a year! And then they agreed.³⁴

The very act of bringing the parties together was believed to sometimes improve outcomes:

Sometimes the parties wouldn't agree to things at a bilateral, but when you get them into a Tripartite, then they'd agree. Funny. Funny kind of a thing you know?³⁵

This corresponds to Collin's observation that the act of coming together can trigger "a change of atmosphere," which is "the starting point for what happens next" (2004, 34).

Tripartite Choreography: Predictability and Affect

[I]t's not easy for them to sit down. And it's not easy for those generals on the LAF side, or the Israeli side to come to that meeting and sit there and represent their people because in some respects, they're being taught its betrayal...and they do argue, but it's civilized argument. Do you know what I mean? And that's not easy. Because they will go to that meeting and have to report back to their respective sides. And they are enemies.³⁶

So we come to the main meeting and everybody knows, or at least I know, what's on the others' agendas, and what's going to be brought up. And then it's just a question of keeping it nice and civilised inside...³⁷

The ritualized structure of the Tripartites provided a predictability that reassured participants. As ritual theorists note, repetition and formality generate a sense of stability even in adversarial encounters (Bell 1992; Collins 2004). In this case, predictability created a space that both enabled and contained emotions, while simultaneously reproducing patterns of mutual blame, and we turn to this dynamic now.

Predictability

The agenda for the Tripartites was always laid out in advance. To draft the agenda, the UNIFIL officers spent weeks in bilateral meetings with both parties to first clarify what they thought were the most urgent issues; and second, to sound out what subjects would be acceptable for discussion at the meeting. The final agenda, however, was written and produced by UNIFIL, and the only input to the agenda in the meeting itself by either of the parties was as "Any Other Business." UNIFIL's focus on ensuring the meetings ran smoothly meant they refused to allow the parties to set the agenda.

³²UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016

³³By ritualized space, we mean an arena made distinct through repetition, formality, and choreography, where interactions are structured in ways that both enable and constrain the parties' engagement.

³⁴Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

³⁵Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

³⁶UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016

³⁷UNIFIL Force Commander A, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

So we'd write out all the talking points so everything was scripted. ...we found at an early stage if you asked them to contribute to the agenda that you were going to fall out...So we prepared an agenda and we presented an agenda. And we said, "If you've any issues after that you can bring it up under Any Other Business". That was our get out of jail thing you know? Otherwise we would never have got them into the room.³⁸

Topics that did not make the cut because they were either considered too sensitive or not urgent enough were put aside with the hope of returning to them later. When asked what was on the agenda, and what was left off, some UNIFIL staff described the decision as instinctive: "You can kind of sense when something should not be discussed. You can feel it."³⁹ Others surmised what went on would largely depend on the seriousness of an event, as well as whether or not the parties were prepared to discuss it outside of the bilateral forums, which were part of the extensive preparations involved prior to each tripartite. Across all these situations, UNIFIL officers went out of their way to reduce uncertainty to a minimum. They expressed awareness that all involved were engaging in a performance at every meeting that was partially scripted, with one officer stating: "the organization and the stage management are nearly as important as what goes on inside."⁴⁰

Affect

Although the Tripartites were usually calm and tightly choreographed, emotions persisted beneath the orderly surface. UNIFIL staff recalled the constant need to manage the parties' feelings as part of the process. Yet the shared affect was antagonistic, grounded in mutual blame and victimhood rather than sympathy or grief for each other's suffering. Ritual theory contends that rituals often contain emotions without resolving them (Bell 1992; Collins 2004; Whitehouse 2004). In this sense, the very structure that kept the meetings composed may also have perpetuated a cycle of blame, enabling negative emotions to be present but never transformed.⁴¹ Notably, over time respondents reported the emotional intensity of the meeting subsided over time. In 2013, an officer reported heated discussions:

...the tripartite meetings allow them to let off steam. If both sides want to shout and yell at each other they can do so. They can let off steam, they can put their points of view, they have very different points of view, they have very forceful arguments but it is an effective forum in that sense. Both sides get a lot out of it.⁴²

A respondent interviewed in 2016 noted this was no longer the case:

So I would say they avoid certain language that might inflame the meeting. So it's what's not said a lot of the time. The absence of you know - because we had a recent one a meeting recently and that's a huge issue over Shebaa Farms. It's been in the media driving everyone nuts. It's kind of died down again. But we thought they'd be a huge argument over this but there wasn't. Because the Lebanese produced documents and a presentation and it was all guarded and nicely put and they registered their complaints in a very civilized manner. I'm told that us initially and after 2006, the meetings were not like that. There was more shouting, but I think as time progresses, they realize there's more to be gained by presenting your

³⁸Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

³⁹UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁴⁰UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁴¹In particular Whitehouse's idea of "doctrinal" modes of rituals. See: Harvey Whitehouse, *Modes of Religiosity: A Cognitive Theory of Religious Transmission* (Walnut Creek, CA: AltaMira Press, 2004).

⁴²UNIFIL Political Affairs Officer, C, Beirut, Lebanon, August 30, 2013.

arguments in a palatable fashion. So they avoid language that would be inflammatory I would say. And that's not easy. Because they will go to that meeting and then have to report back to their respective sides. And they are enemies.⁴³

This finding is consistent with the research of Harvey Whitehouse (2000, 2004), whose "modes of religiosity" framework shows that ritual forms are not fixed. Intense, rare, and emotionally charged "imagistic" rituals, which bind small groups together, can, over time, become routinized as communities expand. Through processes of institutionalization and repetition, these practices morph into the "doctrinal" mode: frequent, standardized rituals that sustain cohesion in larger, more complex groups. In doctrinal mode, emotions are contained but not resolved.⁴⁴

Containing these emotions—if and when they appeared—became part of the choreography of the meetings themselves. For UNIFIL, preventing walkouts and sustaining continuity took precedence over outcomes. Their task was to provide a space where emotion could be expressed but carefully managed, preserving the integrity of a ritual they regarded as both necessary and valuable.

There's no point of going into a meeting, I would suggest, where people are going to get upset and walk out. And it's never happened apparently that they've walked out. So generally speaking, if it's going to be a serious issue, both sides adopt an approach that allows the other side to stay in the room.⁴⁵

Once the meeting was in session, UNIFIL had a number of avoidance tactics for ensuring tensions did not run too high, such as coffee breaks. When the room became heated, UNIFIL officers would change the physical energy in the room by suggesting a coffee break to release the tension.

[S]ometimes it could get very heated and stuff like that. But what we would do if things were getting too hot and heavy and people were getting a little bit itchy and stuff like that, we'd call a coffee break. You know? We could see that something was going to happen so "OK lads let's fall out. Coffee!" So we'd call a coffee break before someone could exit stage left you know?

During the break, officers would create sidebars, working hard to negotiate individually with members of both parties to find a solution.

And then when we got into the coffee rooms then we'd circulate around and talk and take the heat out of it and talk to people who were getting agitated and say, "Listen, you've got to calm it down" or do some negotiation offside, offline with each individual and then bring them back into the room and then maybe have a formula worked out as to how we would address the contentious issue...⁴⁶

This practice seemed driven by a desire to project an appearance of progress, even when little substantive progress was being made. All those interviewed mentioned the process was often two steps forward and three steps back but were insistent that the negotiations were useful and helpful. If sidebars did not work, then staff would resort to deferring an issue rather than having the tension explode and risk one party withdrawing.

Sometimes maybe we might have just kicked the can down the road, but basically what we would try and do is have some formula agreed during the coffee break.⁴⁷

All those interviewed admitted that the forum was not always optimal when dealing with difficult subjects and that deferral of an issue often meant that problems did not get solved. But respondents insisted that this was still preferable to a walkout. The pride UNIFIL officers took in bringing the parties together and keeping them in the room is very evident.

Nobody has ever left the room. Nobody has ever left the room. And maybe you could say we've come close once or twice but nobody has ever left the room.⁴⁸

The tactic used by one experienced officer was to be pragmatic and noncommittal and keep emphasizing that he understood their point of view. In so doing, the officer managed to defuse tension.

You see that actually is the important thing: try to understand each party's position. You don't have to agree with it but you've got to get into their shoes. You've got to get inside their heads and you've got to try and see it from their perspective...And I think if you can do that, well then you're halfway there you know? You could say to some of the parties like, "You know they can't give you that. So why pursue that line?" And again you just have to be careful not to make a promise. You have to say, "I will try... I understand..."⁴⁹

Another way to reassure participants and keep them coming back was to conduct site visits to the scene of the problem. One officer agreed to do this on multiple occasions to convince the parties of his role as an honest broker trying to find a solution. His view was that this was one of the best ways to show his dedication to problem-solving.

Perhaps the clearest sign of the lack of genuine unity between the parties was the fact that UNIFIL always hosted a lunch after the meeting, for which the IDF would stay, but which the LAF never attended.⁵⁰

Defusing emotions through technocracy and military language

Another avoidance tactic used by UNIFIL within the ritual was the strict use of technical and military language along with a focus on everyday practicalities. Strategic concerns and politics were ostentatiously left at the door, even though in reality they were the elephant in the room. Ritual theory suggests that formalized, depersonalized language functions to constrain ambiguity and stabilize interaction (Bloch 1989; Rappaport 1999). In this sense, the Tripartites' reliance on technocratic military language created a controlled dynamic of artificial concord.

The use of military language provided the discursive power that enabled the meetings to function within the ritualized space of the Tripartites despite the occurrence of regular violent incidents on the Blue Line. This lingua franca diffused the politics, turning the meetings into a technocratic space in which to discuss concrete security procedures. Most UNIFIL respondents were adamant that they were not engaged in a political process, stating this was a tactical and operational meeting that focused only on physically marking the Blue Line and managing security incidents on the Blue Line to prevent escalation.

⁴³UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁴⁴Whitehouse, Harvey. *Arguments and Icons: Divergent Modes of Religiosity*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000; Whitehouse, Harvey. *Modes of Religiosity: A Cognitive Theory of Religious Transmission*. Walnut Creek, CA: AltaMira Press, 2004.

⁴⁵UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁴⁶Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

⁴⁷Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

⁴⁸UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Sur, Lebanon, July 16, 2016.

⁴⁹Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

⁵⁰Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

It's a good forum; it does work to satisfy our requirements at this level...It's not going to deal with the bigger issues.⁵¹

[T]he forum is for deconfliction. It's not there to solve the political problems.⁵²

[T]he tripartite mechanism is based on security and military issues relating from UNSC 1701. It does not cover political issues.⁵³

Only one respondent, a political affairs officer, acknowledged that the Tripartites were more than just a tactical and operational mechanism. This reflection is important because it reveals tension between the UNIFIL claim that the meetings were purely technocratic, and the meaning they held for both parties.

It seems that - okay, these are technical issues - but no, they're not. Everything is political. Be it five olive trees or whatever. It's not just about the trees; it's always something about the territory and sovereignty and identity and so on. So these small issues become very big issues.⁵⁴

The official position reiterated to us by most UNIFIL respondents was that the technical framing of the meetings was critical to their continuity. To preserve the stability, they discouraged political actors from joining, fearing their presence would dissuade the LAF and IDF from attending.

I think we have to be careful that we don't attempt to abuse this format. And there have been attempts in the past to ...if you like piggyback on this meeting for other agendas. You know, and I don't think it'd be a favour of that. I think the meeting is well structured, we've heard it 100 times, it's there to keep the peace between Lebanon, and Israel at very much a tactical to operational level, within the UNIFIL area of operations.⁵⁵

Now on one or two occasions we had UNSCOL sit in on a meeting...But the thing was this: Tripartite is a UNIFIL vehicle, it's not an UNSCOL vehicle and often UNSCOL might want to come in and take it over to a certain extent you know? But it was not a political forum - we had to be very careful and very clear - it's a military forum to deconflict between the parties.⁵⁶

Ah, we're not achieving things we might like to achieve. We're always more ambitious like but it's difficult for the parties. A lot of things about 1701 are impacting at the political level which is outside the remit and although it's very successful, it's also very limited in what it can achieve. And this is something we're always looking at: How can we expand the Tripartite to incorporate a little bit more? But you don't want to kill the golden goose you know? ⁵⁷

Emotions and motivations for participation

By maintaining a strictly technical and tactical framing, UNIFIL deferred political discussion, while the parties themselves brought divergent understandings of the meetings' purpose. Their mutual focus on security issues produced only a superficial sense of common ground, and although both the LAF and IDF kept attending, they did so for different reasons. For the IDF, the meetings appeared to be primarily a source of information about developments on the Lebanese side, in particular the activities of Hizballah, whom they regarded as an existential threat. For the LAF, participation seemed to reinforce its claim to be the sole legitimate defender of Lebanese territory.

Despite these different agendas, both sides acknowledged that the Tripartite ritual provided a measure of reassurance. This finding concurs with Bell's (1992) observation that ritual formality can create the appearance of consensus even when beliefs diverge, while Collins (2004) reminds us that repeated encounters generate "emotional energy," offering comfort through predictability, even among adversaries.

We both have to accept that we exist and that happens in that room. It's a physical, it's more than a border. You see a border; you can still ignore the other side. When you're in a room and you are, on the one hand, you have the uniform commander, the other side, you have the UN representatives from New York, and you have the two, you know, the Israeli and the Lebanese side. It's... it's much more, it's a meeting basically between neighbours. So, the ritual in itself, when it happens...what it basically says is it's a question of dual legitimacy. And more than that, it's, if it doesn't happen, it says something about the situation...Because when you don't meet, it's also a message in itself.⁵⁸

And we worked hard in 6 years in order not to go to war...If there is no decision to go to war, we must not go to war over an incident, which can raise the tension in order to which to go to war, without a decision to go to war. Even when there are casualties.⁵⁹

UNIFIL, as the creator of the meetings, regarded it as symbolically vital, and possibly its most important peacebuilding achievement. We suggest this belief led UNIFIL staff to misinterpret the regular occurrence of the meetings as a sign of progress. UNIFIL staff interviewed seemed to believe that despite their insistence on it being a technical meeting, and the complete lack of political progress outside the meetings, there was a chance for this forum to generate peace.

It's all the tiny little steps that build the big ones... It's just hard work...Peace comes dripping slowly, and it's the little things like that, that make all the difference... So the tripartite meetings allow for the little steps towards trust. It's so important that they sit down and talk. And if they don't talk about anything important, so what? The fact that they meet is what's important. And it's the building of that trust.⁶⁰

And to start to build up an effective foundation stone and the basis of trust that could then be possibly built upon at the right time between the right actors, at the right stage, at the political level.⁶¹

So yeah, we're, we're nibbling away at it...But again, you know, I just keep mentioning that permanency is fine, permanency is fine. So it might stick if I keep mentioning it.⁶²

This view was very likely conveyed to New York, and so the tripartite meetings were also regarded by UN headquarters in New York as an extremely positive aspect of UNIFIL's work in maintaining international peace and security, as evidenced by their frequent mention in Secretary General reports which described them as the most significant stabilizing factor within the framework of resolution 1701.⁶³

The peacekeepers engaged in the ritual were strongly oriented toward its preservation. Their efforts concentrated on averting walkouts, containing tensions, and safeguarding the procedural stability of the Tripartite meetings. Operating within this level of interaction, and supported by the

⁵¹ UNIFIL Force Commander, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁵² Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

⁵³ UNIFIL Political Affairs Officer B, Beirut, Lebanon, August 13, 2013.

⁵⁴ UNIFIL Political Affairs Officer C, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁵⁵ UNIFIL Force Commander, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁵⁶ Former UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer, Den Haag, Zoom, April 11, 2022.

⁵⁷ UNIFIL Senior Political Affairs Officer B, Sur, Lebanon, July 16, 2016.

⁵⁸ Interview with IDF officer A, January 12, 2023, Paris, Zoom.

⁵⁹ Lebanese Armed Forces Officer, Beirut, Lebanon, 2013.

⁶⁰ UNIFIL Military Assistant, Planning and Coordination Cell, Tripartite Meetings, Naqoura, South Lebanon, 2016.

⁶¹ UNIFIL Political Affairs Officer A, Beirut, Lebanon, August 13, 2013.

⁶² UNIFIL Force Commander A, Naqoura, South Lebanon.

⁶³ United Nations Secretary General, "Report of the Secretary-General on the Implementation of Security Council Resolution 1701 (2006), S/2013/381," p. 7.

regularity and predictability of the encounters, UNIFIL personnel often developed confident interpretations of the ritual's effectiveness, which at times risked overstating the degree of substantive progress achieved.

The strategic context

Our ritual analysis operates at the microlevel, but it is important to acknowledge that these interactions were embedded in broader strategic dynamics that shaped their possibilities and limitations. UN Resolution 1701 was never designed to address the root causes of the conflict; instead, it focused narrowly on creating a buffer zone between the Litani River and the Blue Line. Following the 2006 war, Israel's perception of its own unsatisfactory performance, combined with a deep mistrust of UNIFIL's capacity to foster peace, set the stage for a deterrence relationship with Hizballah. Over time Hizballah gradually reestablished its presence in South Lebanon (Meier 2016), and tit-for-tat exchanges intensified mutual suspicion making it increasingly difficult for UNIFIL to implement Resolution 1701.

Within this context, the Tripartites emerged as a grassroots initiative with limited scope, oriented toward managing operational issues on the border rather than addressing underlying political disputes, not least because they did not include Hizballah. Their significance, therefore, lay not in resolving strategic tensions, but in demonstrating how ritual practices at the microlevel can sustain day-to-day engagement in the shadow of unresolved conflict.

A latent hope that the meetings might eventually generate a larger peace settlement was possibly partly why they were sustained by UNIFIL as a purely tactical and operational mechanism, which constantly worked to "keep people in the room." The meetings may also have made UNIFIL feel they were making a difference in a conflict that appeared to have no obvious resolution or exit strategy for the mission. If UNIFIL had not kept politics out of the meetings, might a more honest exchange have occurred? Could UNIFIL have introduced a strategic element that might have brought political solutions to what remains an essentially political problem? Given the destruction that occurred in October and November 2024, at best it would appear that the Tripartites failed to prevent a larger conflict, and at worst it is possible to conjecture that the conflict was bigger than if a breakdown between the parties had occurred earlier, because the semblance of calm—that prevented sudden escalations between the IDF and the LAF—gave the IDF and Hizballah more time to rearm and prepare for a new conflict. Had more altercations occurred on the Blue Line, it is highly probable that an escalation would have drawn Hizballah and the IDF into conflict far sooner.⁶⁴

As noted above, the parties' differing understandings of the purpose of the meetings highlight how the ritual form of the Tripartites could obscure their divergent political ambitions. Although none of the actors, whether military representatives or UN peacekeepers, can be faulted for this, the shared focus on concrete security issues created an appearance of civility and alignment. For UNIFIL, this sometimes suggested a level of common purpose that did not in fact exist and may have encouraged hopes that the meetings could evolve into a broader peace process.

Conclusion

In this article we asked two questions: How do rituals function in peace and conflict settings? How do rituals between adversaries contain and sustain emotions? In this article, we showed how a ritual can be constituted and sustained through military diplomacy. Furthermore, we unpacked the emotional dynamics of this ritual and showed how it both contains and perpetuates antagonistic emotions.

We find that while the ritual itself provided a safe space for interaction between two parties at war, it did not help the parties move forward. The parties shared emotion but failed to create a shared reality; rather, the affect that lingered throughout was antagonistic, located in mutual blame, injustice, and victimhood. While the ritual helped to reduce information asymmetries and prevent escalations, it also served to create a holding space, a false equilibrium that sustained hostilities and removed the need for either side to take responsibility for their actions.

This article makes several contributions to the IR literature. We provide a rich empirical illustration of how a ritual functions in a peace and conflict setting. An underexplored dimension of the peacekeeping literature is how diplomatic initiatives by peacekeepers allow warring parties to interact and reach agreements on issues of mutual importance. In this article, we reveal the origins and anatomy of a ritual: How it began, why it was a ritual, and how it was sustained, an important empirical contribution to the extent literature on both practices and rituals (Goffman 1967; Bell 1992; Whitehouse 2000, 2004; Collin 2004). Relatedly, our findings also speak to ongoing discussions about the future of peacekeeping and multilateralism, in which smaller, less ambitious peace-making initiatives, such as the Tripartites are likely to gain traction.⁶⁵

Ritual theory, following Durkheim (1912), assumes that rituals generate collective effervescence: shared emotions that bind participants into a moral community.⁶⁶ Later theorists extend this view, emphasizing *communitas* or "emotional energy" as the integrative outcome of ritual encounters (Victor 1969; Collins 2004).⁶⁷ Our case complicates and extends this argument. In the Tripartites, emotion was ever-present but took antagonistic forms—mutual blame, resentment, and victimhood—that reinforced perceptions of the other as an enemy, rather than dissolving division. The ritual endured not because it fostered solidarity, but because it provided a predictable channel to contain and reproduce these antagonistic emotions. In this way, we contribute to ritual theory by showing that rituals in conflict settings can stabilize adversarial relations without producing the cohesion that Durkheimian accounts would predict. Rigid structures, combined with avoidance tactics such as the use of technical language and a focus on technocratic, everyday security concerns, helped to preserve this mechanism of military diplomacy, while failing to afford it the benefits of rituals such as a shared reality, shared morality, emotional connection, and solidarity. This finding also complements the microsociological literature that has mostly focused on the political level and on agents with ampler margins of maneuver (Bramsen 2023). Hence, we respond to the call by Solomon and Steele to "ontologize the

⁶⁵See for instance: <https://www.sciencespo.fr/en/news/israel-hezbollah-ceasefire-deal-promises-a-precarious-peace-in-a-region-racked-by-conflict/>

⁶⁶Émile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, trans. Karen E. Fields (New York: Free Press, 1995 [1912]).

⁶⁷Victor Turner, *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine, 1969); Randall Collins, *Interaction Ritual Chains* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2004).

⁶⁴The evidence for this belief is based on an interview with UNIFIL whereby an officer confirmed that during the 2010 Al-Adeiseh shoot out, it was possible Hizballah had positioned itself in the area and was also shooting, although this could not be confirmed.

micropolitical formation demarcating the scope conditions of the entity being examined" (Solomon and Steele 2017, 280).

For practitioners, this research highlights the importance of recognizing that ritualized and habitual meetings are not neutral; they can entrench patterns as much as they ease tensions. Future research should explore how different forms of ritualization shape outcomes across peacekeeping missions and diplomatic forums, and under what conditions rituals enable genuine reconciliation rather than simply deferring political confrontation. Such insights would help peacekeepers and mediators design encounters that not only keep adversaries "in the room," but also create openings for more transformative dialogue. Future scholarship could also zoom in on specific micro crises within a conflict to disentangle how rituals—such as the Tripartites—can be conducive to containing an escalation or simply help to sustain it. Along similar lines, future research could also potentially explore the role played by Hizballah's absence in shaping the very scope and function of the ritual.

In sum, this article highlights how rituals, even if with the best of intentions, can "go bad" and fail to bring people together. Accordingly, this research offers valuable empirical insights for military and diplomatic actors engaged in the management of protracted conflicts, as well as for civilian-led conflict-resolution initiatives that emphasize the performative act of "showing up" to signal a shared commitment of purpose. Ultimately, this article shows that presence and the creation of safe spaces for dialogue are not sufficient to engender genuine feelings of reconciliation or rapprochement. The Tripartites kept an open channel of communication between archenemies that contributed to an appearance of calm that lasted 18 years, but it is conceivable that very longevity, sustained by the ritual itself, helped contribute to its ugly end.

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